fourdayweek_v48

Mahindra University - Mahindra Ecole Centrale

Document Details

Submission ID
trn:oid:::26334:467426515

Submission Date
Oct 26, 2026, 1:04 PM GMT+5:30

Download Date
Oct 26, 2026, 1:11 PM GMT+5:30

File Name
fourdayweek_v48.docx

File Size
38.5 KB

4 Pages

1,032 Words

5,495 Characters

0% detected as AI

The percentage indicates the combined amount of likely AI-generated text as well as likely AI-generated text that was also likely revised by AI.

Caution: Review required.

It is essential to understand the limitations of AI detection before making decisions about a student's work. We encourage you to learn more about Turnitin's AI detection capabilities before using the tool.

0 AI-generated 0%

Likely generated or likely generated and revised by AI.

Disclaimer

Our AI writing assessment is designed to help educators identify text that might be prepared by a generative AI tool. Our AI writing assessment may not always be accurate (it may misidentify writing that is likely human generated as AI generated and likely AI generated as human generated) so it should not be used as the sole basis for adverse actions against a student. It takes further scrutiny and human judgment in conjunction with an organization's application of its specific academic policies to determine whether any academic misconduct has occurred.

Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of a four-day working week

A four-day working week, by which employees complete their normal duties within four longer days instead of the conventional five, has moved from a fringe experiment to a serious policy proposal in several national debates (Autonomy, 2023). Trials in Portugal, together with a number of British firms and a cluster of private employers in the service sector, have been completed between 2022 and 2024. Behind the proposal rests a simple observation, repeated across the recent reviews of working time (Autonomy, 2023), namely that the hours spent at a desk and the work actually completed differ in every important respect. This second quantity, according to the supporters of the reform, does not grow in proportion to the first. Shorter weeks, in the words of these supporters, function as an instrument for raising productivity and retaining staff. Critics, on the other hand, warns that the same arrangement may compress more pressure into fewer days, particularly in the sectors where the work must be delivered in person. This essay, therefore, will examine both the benefits and drawbacks of the four-day week, with particular attention to the sectors involved, and argue that its value depends to the design of the trial rather than on the principle itself.

A four-day week's premier advantage lies in the productivity gains which follow from a shorter and better organise working day. In the United Kingdom, the largest trial, coordinated by the research group Autonomy, covered sixty-one companies. Revenue, in most of the participating firms, stay broadly the same or improved, with staff turnover falling sharply and sick leave reduced by roughly two thirds in the participating firms (Autonomy, 2023). Similar results were recorded by the New Zealand insurer Perpetual Guardian, where the shift to four days came with a measurable rise in output per worker,

with the management attributing this rise to shorter meetings and clearer priorities (Barnes, 2020). Such evidence suggests that a substantial share of the working week disappear into activities which add little value, including unnecessary meetings, repeated emails and informal interruptions (Barnes, 2020). Removal of these costs, in other words, can funds the lost day without any reduction in output.

Besides the improvement in output, a shorter week also produces benefits which fall outside the balance sheet. Employees who gain a weekday report better sleep, more time with their families and a reduction in feelings of exhaustion which accumulate across the week. These improvements appears in the health measures collected during the British trial, together with the self-reports gathered by the Icelandic experiments between 2015 and 2019, where the reduction of the formal week covered a much larger share of the public sector (Haraldsson and Kellam, 2021). The recruitment effect deserves equal attention as well, since firms which offers four days receives more applications per vacancy, and the retention of experienced staff, in the longer run, carry a value which rarely appears in the accounts. Training of a replacement, particularly in the professions where it requires years, make this hidden value larger than the salary saving alone.

This picture darkens, however, once the working time are examined from the side of the customer. In the sectors where the service must be delivered in person, including hospitals, schools, transport and retail, the shortening of the week does not reduce the hours which the organisation must cover. The same coverage, under such conditions, must be provide by more staff, by longer shifts, or by a mixture of the two arrangements. British trials concentrated disproportionately on the office-based firms, whose output, unlike that of an hospital ward, does not depend on the physical presence of the worker at

a particular hour. These results, for this reason, is difficult to transfer to the sectors which employ a larger share of the workforce. An arrangement which improves the lives of software engineers, in other words, may leave a nurse with the same number of hours compressed into fewer and longer days (Barnes, 2020). Fatigue of this kind, in most of the published accounts, hardly counts as an improvement over the conventional pattern.

Another drawback of the four-day week is the intensification of work which accompanies the compression of the same output into less time. Employees in the trials report that the shorter week feels less like a gift of free time than a demand for greater concentration. Informal breaks, in many of these firms, have been removed and the pace of working day increased (Haraldsson and Kellam, 2021). Such an arrangement may therefore function as a transfer of the productivity gain from the worker to the employer. A similar logic applies to the boundaries of the working day, because where the client's demands, rather than the firm's own schedule, set the volume of work, as in the legal and consulting professions, the reduction of available days is frequently followed by the extension of the working evening. Total hours, under this arrangement, may remain unchanged while the formal week pass for a shorter one.

To conclude, a four-day week is not only an effective instrument for raising productivity in the office-based sectors, but employees can also gain improvements in health and family life which carry a value beyond the wage. Nevertheless, the arrangement can be deceptive in effect, since the same reduction of the formal week may compress the same work into fewer and longer days. Sectors which require continuous coverage are rarely able to adopt it on the same terms, as the health trials showed (Haraldsson and Kellam, 2021). Despite these concerns, the four-day week should still be tested rather than

rejected, with the trials designed for measure output and health together. Coverage requirements of the front-line services should be treated as a separate problem, so that the shorter week is delivered as a genuine reduction of work rather than as a compression of the same burden.

Word count: 968

References

Autonomy. (2023). The results of the world's largest four-day week trial. Autonomy Research Ltd.

Barnes, A. (2020). Perpetual Guardian's four-day week: An evaluation. University of Auckland Business School.

Haraldsson, G. D., & Kellam, J. (2021). Going public: Iceland's journey to a shorter working week. Alda and Association for Sustainable Democracy.